CGV Beta Feedback — What Your Tutor Wants

1. The main feedback, decoded

Area	What your tutor wants	Priority
Level design	Three genuinely distinct levels, not just different rooms in the same area	**Critical**
Winning and losing	A clear success condition and failure condition for each level	**High**
Custom shaders	Actual custom shaders visible in gameplay, with technical explanations	**High**
Restart	Restart the game without refreshing the browser	**High**
Save and resume	Leave the game and return to the same progress, if feasible	**High**
Camera/viewing	First-person and third-person switching, or convincing equivalent viewing functionality	**Medium**
Innovation	Something memorable that distinguishes the game from other submissions	**High**
Quality of life	Better menus, controls, settings, credits and accessibility	**Medium**
Textures and lighting	Demonstrate and explain the graphics techniques being used	**High**
Devlog	A video explaining the development process and technical implementation	**Required for final**

The priorities are my interpretation of his comments, not additional marks he explicitly assigned.

2. His biggest criticism: The levels don't feel different enough

This seems to be the most significant point in the transcript.

He essentially says that everything still happens in the same general environment, with different rooms representing different levels.

He wants each level to have a distinct identity and gameplay challenge.

That doesn't necessarily mean we need to throw away the existing story or rebuild the entire circus.

We could strengthen what already exists:



Level 1 — Talk Her Down

Social interaction and consequential choices

Ribbit's emotional state becomes the challenge. The player needs to select dialogue options carefully.

Win: Stabilise Ribbit enough to complete the encounter.

Lose: Ribbit's condition deteriorates beyond the level's failure threshold.

The environment should visually react to her condition, perhaps through distortions or unstable lighting.



Level 2 — Missing Pieces

Exploration, investigation and item collection

Create a darker investigative atmosphere around Kaufmo's missing evidence.

Win: Find and collect all three required photographs.

Lose: For example, fail a meaningful environmental challenge or detection mechanic, if we choose to add one.

This level should feel like a mystery, not another dialogue exercise.



Level 3 — Into the Maze

Timed navigation and pressure

Search for the bowling ball and hot chocolate mug while racing against time.

Win: Retrieve the required items and reach the exit before time expires.

Lose: The timer reaches zero, triggering a clear failure screen and retry option.

This is the most straightforward place to demonstrate unmistakable win/loss states.

The win/loss conditions above are proposed designs based on your team's storyline, not confirmed implemented features.

3. His point about winning versus story endings

This was one of the most important things he explained.

A bad narrative ending isn't necessarily the same thing as losing a level.

For example:

- You finish the level successfully but your choices increase Pomni's corruption or worsen her eventual fate. That's a narrative consequence.
- You fail to collect the required evidence before a timer expires. That's a gameplay failure.

Your tutor seems to want both systems to be understandable.

Recommended game progression

Complete a level objective	
Success Continue story; choices affect future events and endings.	**Failure** Show a clear failure state and allow retry from a checkpoint.

That distinction will help us explain our game much more confidently.

4. Custom shaders: He wants to see them, not just hear about them

Your tutor seems to be saying that everyone should know which shaders are used, where they're used and how they work.

For example, we could have:

Shader	Visible effect	Technical explanation
Glitch shader	Environment distorts as danger increases	Time-driven vertex displacement or fragment colour offsets
Pulsing shader	Magical circus objects glow rhythmically	Time uniform controls emissive-like fragment colour
Dissolve shader	Evidence, portals or characters visibly dissolve	Noise or threshold function controls alpha/discard

These are suggestions—not evidence that the game currently implements them.

Also, textures are not automatically custom shaders. Three.js built-in materials support textures and lighting, but custom shader work generally means code such as ShaderMaterial, RawShaderMaterial or custom GLSL injection.

I think we should audit the repository and choose two or three already-visible opportunities rather than inventing completely new rendering systems.

And during the final demonstration, a teammate should be able to explain:

This is our custom fragment shader. It changes the pixel colour based on a time uniform. We use it during the maze to create a pulsing warning effect.

That would provide both visible and technical evidence.

5. Restart, saving and quality of life

His requested features seem to fall into two categories.

Essential usability:

- A Restart button that resets the current game without reloading the browser.
- Clear success/failure screens with Retry and Continue options.
- Usable controls and credits from the menu.
- More polished, consistent UI and quieter audio if needed.

More advanced quality of life:

- Saving progress so the player can return later.
- Resume from the last checkpoint.
- Persisting narrative choice variables.
- Camera-view options.

For saving, we don't need a backend database. For a browser game, a versioned localStorage save could store the active level, completed objectives, story scores and appropriate checkpoint. We would still need to restore character position and mission state safely.

One important distinction: in-game restart and persistence across browser sessions are separate features. We should test them separately.

6. Innovation — what sets your group apart?

Your tutor's question was essentially:

If another group recreated a Digital Circus game, what would make yours memorable?

I think your strongest existing idea is that the player's decisions affect later events and the ultimate ending.

Rather than abandoning that, I'd make the consequences visible.

For example, a decision made during Ribbit's interaction could alter how Jax treats Pomni later, or change environmental details in the maze. If the player can actually observe those consequences, the innovation becomes more convincing.

You already have other potential distinguishing features: Pomni's authored wake animation, the animated blanket, the character staging, the tutorial and the minimap. But the most defensible gameplay innovation could be meaningful consequences carried across three different types of challenges.

7. What he said about the devlog

The transcript indicates that your tutor wants a video development log, not merely a written diary.

His explanation seems to be that the video should:

- Show what the team built.
- Demonstrate the game and development stages.
- Explain the technical decisions at a medium-to-high level.
- Include enough detail about how the system works.
- Show evidence of the work done.

He also suggested looking at strong devlogs from previous years.

We should distinguish that from a promotional trailer: a devlog explains the making of the game; a trailer sells the game experience.

8. My recommended order of work

1 **Audit all three levels and their completion conditions**

Identify what each level actually requires, how the player wins, how they fail, and where the level sends them next.

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2 **Audit and demonstrate custom shaders**

This is explicitly called out by your tutor and contributes to the graphics rubric.

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3 **Implement restart and save/resume**

Check the existing game state architecture before adding storage or resetting systems.

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4 **Improve level distinction and polish**

Establish visually and mechanically different areas, refine menus and credits, and highlight the game's innovation.

One thing I want to emphasise

Your tutor's overall feedback sounds constructive rather than dismissive. He appears to recognise the visual work and the consequences-based storytelling, but wants a game that more clearly demonstrates the full rubric.

He also said he would complete a fuller playthrough before finalising marks, so we shouldn't treat these comments as the final mark.

I would not spend more time polishing Pomni's opening cinematic right now. That part already demonstrates substantial animation and narrative work.

Our next move should be a full Codex audit against these exact tutor comments. From there, we can turn each item into a verified issue, assign it a priority and avoid rebuilding anything teammates already implemented.

Most importantly, we now know what he means by turning an okay game into a great one: clearly different levels, explicit win/loss states, visible technical graphics work, reliable restart/save features, and small but thoughtful usability improvements.